

[«--back to story](#)

Ribbon cutting planned at restored train station

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LISBON - When property on South Market Street was acquired in the 1990s to build a separate home for the Columbiana County Engineer's Office, an old train station was part of the deal.

Located across South Market Street from where the engineer's office complex would be built stood the former Pittsburgh & Lake Erie Railroad station. County Engineer Bert Dawson recalled looking at the crumbling train station and thought it would be a shame to raze the historical structure.

"We had to do something or end up with a slag parking lot," he said. "It would have been a shame to tear it down."

Dawson opted to do something, and now five years and \$815,000 later, the train station has been restored to its original appearance. A ribbon-cutting ceremony is scheduled for 2 p.m. Thursday.

The railroad operated from the 1880s until it went out of business in the 1940s, after which the two-story brick train station became the home for several businesses, the last being a feed mill, which closed in the 1990s.

Dawson was able to obtain \$815,000 in state and federal funding to pay for the restoration, which included using the original windows and stained-glass windows, woodwork, wood flooring and door casing and hardware.

A recent photograph taken by Dawson's staff of the finished product compares favorably to a photograph of the train station from the 1930s.

"It's about identical, other than the 1935 Pontiac (parked outside)," Dawson said of the two photos. "Terry McCoy (the architect) did a fantastic job of recreating what was here."

Dawson has been collecting historic train paraphernalia that will be displayed at the train station, which eventually will be opened to the public several days per week. He is seeking donated old glass display cases for these items.

Also on display in a frame will be an old U.S. flag with 48 stars, which was found in the train station by workers. The last time a U.S. flag had 48 stars would have been the mid-1950s.

The train station will serve as the southern terminus of the Little Beaver Creek Greenway Trail. To the rear of the station are a pavilion, picnic tables, outside public bathrooms and a bicycle air pump for trail users. Vending machines are to be added later. The county park district, which oversees the bike trail, is to be given use of some space on the second floor for offices and board meetings.

Restoring historical structures is nothing new to Dawson and his staff, who over the years chose to maintain the county's steel-truss bridges when it would have been cheaper to replace them with modern concrete structures.

When the Centennial Covered Bridge in Salem Township, one of the few left in the county, needed reconstructed, Dawson found \$300,000 in federal and state money to help do the job. When an old iron bridge was decommissioned, he held onto it rather than sell it for scrap in the hope an organization may find a use for it someday.

Dawson said he is all for progress.

"We have to move forward ... but when we can preserve something, that's important, too."

Article Photos



The former Pittsburgh & Lake Erie Railroad station in Lisbon has been restored and will house parks offices and serve as an end point for the Greenway bike trail. (Photo by Jo Ann Bobby-Gilbert)